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Maneka Gandhi

Every ant, every bird, every elephant is important to our own well being. Therefore, we need to nurture their habitat and them, if we are to survive.

a MRJ presentation



Ar. Satish Shetty



CINEMATIC EXPERIENCE

Cinema is a very young art form with extraordinary techniques and impressive special effects. The concept of the conventional movie hall has gone a long way in recent times. Interiors play a vital role and Mumbai based Architectural firm **Arris Architects Pvt Ltd** , explains the crucial makeover of Inox and Fun Cinemas that is thrilling, comfortable and will certainly make your visit worthy.

Photo credits: Ajinkya Manohar



Ar. Subhashish Modi









Creating a larger-than-life experiences, designing public spaces, copious in scale and volume, giving importance to interiors and its allied elements, makes the design approach at Arris Architects, Mumbai; people sensitive and program conscious. **Ar. Subhashish Modi, Principal and Director** with his partner, **Ar. Satish Shetty, Director**, strongly believes in bringing in-depth understanding and application of concepts with valued insights to every project, they cater to. The Cinema halls are the most visited places for entertainment, fun and relaxation. These designers bring a package of magic with more masti for movie lovers. Let's enjoy!

Creating an image

A few years back when **Inox** announced acquisition of Fame Cinemas; it was one of the landmark acquisitions in the cinema industry. When Inox planned to revive one

of the flagship properties of Fame Cinemas in Inorbit mall, Malad; it was a huge responsibility for Arris Architects to translate the aspirations, expectations and the vision that it stood for.

Partial renovation and part restoration project, the program required creating a solution for six screen multiplex with one Gold Class and a central box office. Elaborating the design, Ar. Modi adds, "The biggest challenge was to keep cinemas running, fully functional and completely operational, both logistically and economically. Entire lobby had to be divided into phases depending of the size of the auditoriums and schedule it so that maximum seating capacity is available for big releases scheduled during renovation. It also meant that the design had to be such that it could be executed in phases as per work progress without its integrity being hampered."

The revised layout required re-arrangement of core functions such as F & B counters and allied functions, which included realigning existing services to a new location. It was also impossible to check the configuration and condition of the other services such as fire fighting and HVAC without a start of demolition. Hence, the design had to take into consideration all these factors at the same time not let these parameters influence the aesthetical requirement of the space design.

Giving utmost importance to the patrons and their experience of leisure and relaxation, the central lobby, a common spill-out space was intentionally kept large, lavish and luminous! To tie the varied proportions of height and their utilities together, fabric drapes, cascading down the roof, were instrumental in giving a continuous binding illusion.

Building an identity

"Our aim was not only create an impression, but a unique one in itself. We were looking for an element that is unique and yet broadly encompassing. While looking for inspirations, we found one in the form of fingerprints. It speaks of something which everyone possesses and yet is unique to



Core Team

Shubhashish Modi
Satish Shetty
Ajinkya Manohar







one," explains Ar. Modi. The chandelier in plan uses a part of fingerprint pattern as an artistic motif, which is then carried forward onto adjacent walls as a reflective element constituting a design language. The back wall of the concession counters and box office use it as a design emblem and once again ties together all fragments of visual memory. It has been carried forward in cinema sidewalls a continuation of the design language throughout the experience of cinema. "We believe that the aim of renovations should not only be to glitter up the spaces but improving circulation and user functionality. Previous layout of the theatre lobby had a central F&B Counter (Concession Counter) which divided the lobby into two parts and thereby reducing the available space in a linear lobby and volume and also reducing the visibility of the cinema entrances. It made the space cluttered up and claustrophobic even though there was space and volume available for exploitation," further adds Ar. Modi.

Arris devised a layout, pushing back the concession counter towards the end of the lobby and freeing up the central double height volume. The space freed by shifting previous concession counter is used as a seating area; making end user, the focal point of the entire design. The lobby area is equidistant and visible from this point. Placed directly below the chandelier, one can sit, appreciate and take in the soothing ambience of the space.

The placing of F & B kiosks in low height areas near the entrance was to make sure that first impression is always that of the space design and not of the kiosks. However, being close to the entrance, they are easily accessible once a person enters and proceeds towards the seating area.

Entire lobby is divided into three parts as per height: low height at entrance, double height in the centre and again low height towards the end. A drape element was introduced, which originates at the lobby entrance as group of lines running on both sides along the length of the lobby radiating out in the double height space forming a volume enclosure housing a central chan-







delier. The climax of the running drapes culminates into a flood of light that livens up the place by custom made, chandelier. It's a composition of ceiling suspended acrylic tubes with an inlay of miniature LED lights were randomly infused within the organic sequence to appease the soothing semblance. The entire renovation, from ground zero to up, was completed in commendable time of ten months, in spite of frequent logistic irregularities. Major work was carried out at nights to aid the functions of the multiplex during the day. An area of 3500 Sq m was successfully executed under skilled supervised inspection. Clients were immensely satisfied with the outcome of the renovation and it has become a reference point for future projects.

Creating a lasting impression

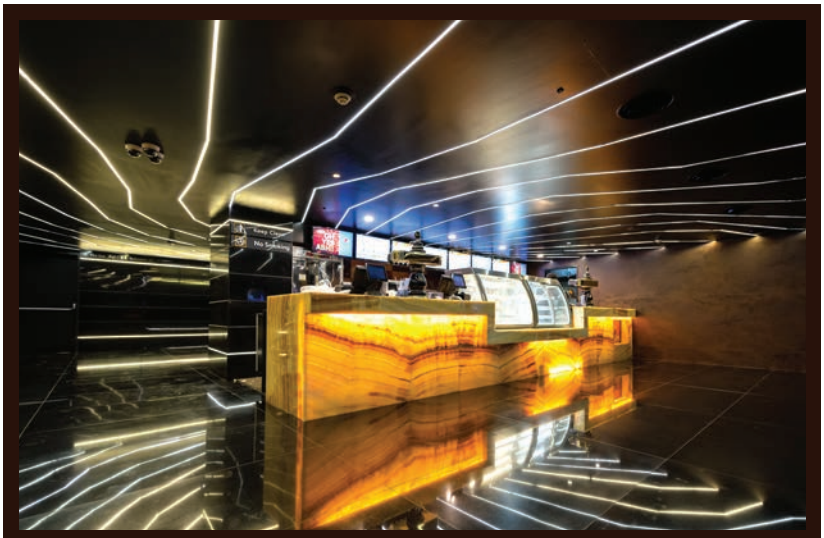
Fun Cinemas, Andheri was one of the first and frequently visited multiplexes in the



city. However, in the megacity that is constantly transforming and the rise in competition posed a struggle for its relevance. It became necessary to adapt and upgrade to changing times and elevate the cinema experience to a completely new level.

A four screen multiplex seating approximately 1000 patrons is accessible from two cinema lobbies, one low height lobby and another with a double height at different levels. Renovation goes a step further than innovation to consider the past and prepare for the future. Arris Architects were posed with the challenging task of reviewing existing concepts, functions, services and renovating the entire design with a futurist, yet contextual outlook. It was a challenge to conceptualize a theme that would hold together completely different spatial configurations of both lobbies along with approaching corridors.

Entry glass doors were removed and



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lobbies were opened out, allowing everyone to get a glimpse and feel of the ambience. Lower concession lobby with lower heights was visualized as trajectories of lines in derived from the Fibonacci sequence around the main concession counter; expressed purely in the form of lights in the ceiling as well as reflection on the floor providing a visual envelope for backlit onyx counter. An intimate play of geometric patterns in shades of stone veneer provides a warm backdrop for the comfortable seating sofas.

Cinema corridors are flanked by a series of suspended acrylic panels of different shades, textures of copper; backlit with LED lights from the ceiling enabling one to feel the texture without touching it. Arrays of these panels are also suspended above the concession counter of the upper level concession lobby with integrated signage. Backlit tiger onyx front accentuates exclusiveness of the F&B counter.

The walls are clad with high gloss wooden panelling with steel inlays in horizontal direction. Auditoriums are an elite enclosure subtly shifting the focal point to the cinema watching experience; accentuating its cosiness and comfort.

Restroom layouts were de-congested and layout was simplified giving a spacious feel. Toilets were clad with a rich combination of marble with Armani Grey. Even though heights were as low as eight feet in the restrooms, new layout helped the space look more spacious.

Lines, light and texture

Analogous to movie making; the complete experience attempts to create a spatial drama with lines and lights, patterns and palettes, textures and materials and the result is a one equally engaging, entertaining and enchanting spatial experience.

Existing cinema lobbies were in contrast with each other one being low and one being a double height was not able to connect the patron with a cinematic experience and barely catered to its functional requirement. Food counters were designed in 'L' shape which did not provide a clear









view of the available menu and it was also in conflict with the queuing directions. Back areas were insufficient due to lack of space and access. Cinemas corridors had become dingy due to lack of lighting and the design of the corridors needed an upgrade. It became important to re-visualize the complete project from point zero. Lift lobby was included in the design scheme forming a preface to the lobby space. The ambience in the lobby provided a niche setting similar to a lounge.

Cinema corridors were panelled to minimize the structural offsets which accentuated the length of the corridor also helping to identify cinema entrances effectively with use of suitable signage. One of the four auditoriums was equipped with Dolby Atmos sound system; providing a new upgraded cinema experience. Thicker and more porous seat fabric increasing the cushioning, the comfort and wooden armrests are detail highlights of the cinema experience. Recliners were coupled with details such as ornate lamp shades. This renovation project was a great success in projecting a design language which stood for the new age cinema revolution; trying to connect to user at a subconscious level. It has contributed to further strengthen the credibility of the practice.

Know about Arris

Team Arris, an interesting mix of highly skilled professionals who contribute design, planning, development, & project management is his pride. Their collective contributions have compiled a strong comprehensive portfolio of diverse commercial, residential and office interiors, specializing in mall, cinema design and architecture. Arris has a comprehensive approach to architecture that embraces pragmatics - real estate asset management, life cycle costs, organizational churn and workplace behaviour, budget and schedule - as essential components of design.

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